

Heating failure in cold weather

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use dry layers, blankets and a smaller dry room while you identify safe heat or a warmer reachable place. Never use a gas oven, barbecue or generator to heat indoors. Confusion, slurred speech, unusual drowsiness or poor coordination can mean hypothermia: seek urgent care and begin safe warming.

Do now.

- ☐ **Get dry and insulated**
01 Replace wet clothes, layer loose dry clothing and insulate beneath the body as well as above it. Keep vulnerable people away from draughts.
- ☐ **Use one workable space**
02 Choose a dry room that remains safe and has a usable exit. Close unnecessary interior doors without blocking ventilation needed by approved heating appliances.
- ☐ **Avoid combustion shortcuts**
03 Use only heating equipment approved for indoor use according to its instructions, with working CO alarms. A grill, oven or indoor generator is not a backup heater.
- ☐ **Check people regularly**
04 Cold can impair judgement. Pay particular attention to infants, older people and anyone with illness or limited mobility. Do not rely on a person saying they feel fine.
- ☐ **Move before severe exposure**
05 Confirm a warmer destination and safe route while people can still travel. Do not cross dangerous ice or an active hazard merely to reach a public warming centre.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use the safest dry shelter and insulation available while confirming a warmer private or community destination. Leave early if you cannot keep vulnerable people warm rather than waiting for official shelter.

Watch for.

Do not give alcohol as a warming method or rub frostbitten skin. Fuel-burning devices can create lethal CO even when you cannot smell anything.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: get dry and insulated. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not give alcohol as a warming method or rub frostbitten skin. Fuel-burning devices can create lethal CO even when you cannot smell anything.

Keep essentials within reach.

For heating failure in cold weather, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Use the safest dry shelter and insulation available while confirming a warmer private or community destination. Leave early if you cannot keep vulnerable people warm rather than waiting for official shelter. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Contact a qualified repair provider when reachable and safe. Plan for medication storage, food, water and sanitation during a longer outage; a portable heater alone does not solve all needs.

First decision: Get dry and insulated

Replace wet clothes, layer loose dry clothing and insulate beneath the body as well as above it. Keep vulnerable people away from draughts. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Use the safest dry shelter and insulation available while confirming a warmer private or community destination. Leave early if you cannot keep vulnerable people warm rather than waiting for official shelter. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not give alcohol as a warming method or rub frostbitten skin. Fuel-burning devices can create lethal CO even when you cannot smell anything. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Use dry layers, blankets and a smaller dry room while you identify safe heat or a warmer reachable place. Never use a gas oven, barbecue or generator to heat indoors. Confusion, slurred speech, unusual drowsiness or poor coordination can mean hypothermia: seek urgent care and begin safe warming. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For heating failure in cold weather, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not give alcohol as a warming method or rub frostbitten skin. Fuel-burning devices can create lethal CO even when you cannot smell anything.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Move before severe exposure. Confirm a warmer destination and safe route while people can still travel. Do not cross dangerous ice or an active hazard merely to reach a public warming centre. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Extreme cold · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/cold>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/heating-failure/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.